

Composition

The arrangement of elements in a work of art is imperative. 'Good' composition attracts and holds interest, while 'bad' composition repels. Focal points, or centres of interest, draw viewers into images, and also important are shape, proportion, balance, harmony, negative and positive space, horizontal, vertical or diagonal lines, and tone, rhythm and viewpoint. Certain compositional arrangements are used repeatedly by painters, such as triangular or pyramidal, which create a sense of harmony, or x-shaped, as seen in Van Gogh's *Café Terrace at Night* and Cézanne's *The Card Players*. Another effective arrangement is 'the rule of thirds', developed from the golden mean or golden ratio. Used extensively during the Renaissance, this uses mathematical proportions to create balanced compositions. Using only vertical and horizontal elements and primary colours, Piet Mondrian created stable compositions representing positive and negative, masculine and feminine. While asymmetry can create a sense of stability and balance, asymmetry, as in many *Ukiyo-e* compositions, can be more interesting and dynamic.



Cézanne, *The Card Players*, 1894–5